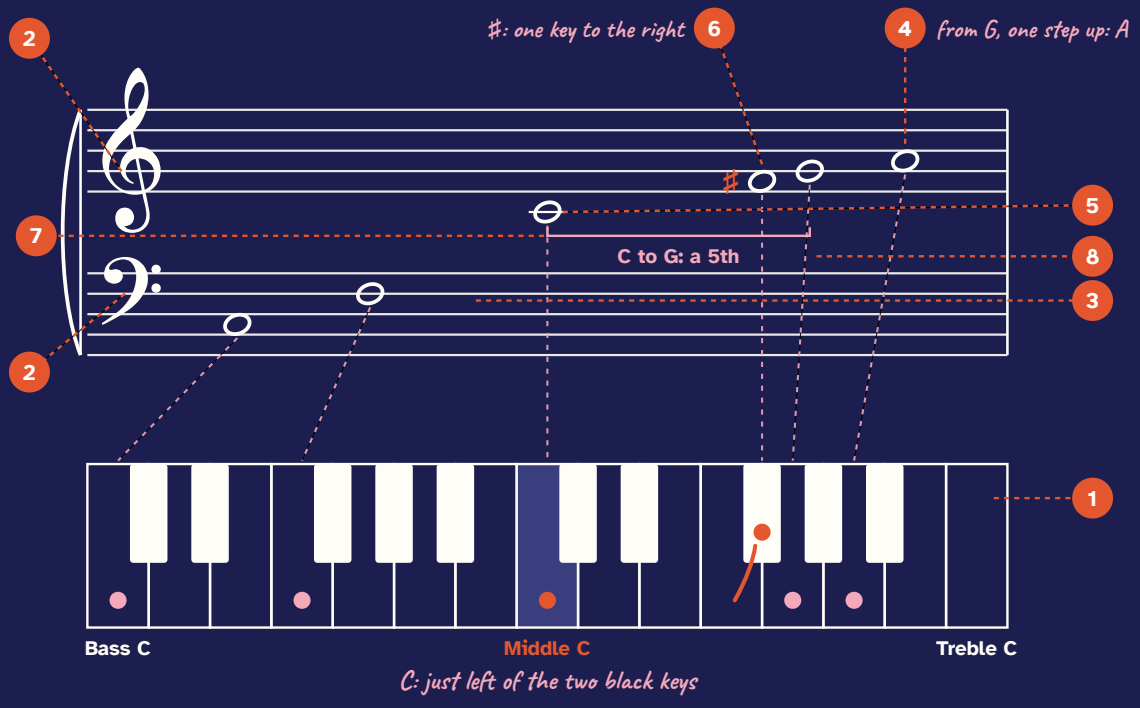
PART I · WHICH NOTE

Pitch

High or low? That is the first question every note answers. Start with the keys under your fingers, find where they live on the staff, see how sharps and flats move them, then measure how far apart two notes are. Everything in this part is in this one picture.



1 **The keyboard** p. 22
two and three black keys; C is left of the two

2 **The staff and the clefs** p. 27
the treble clef names G, the bass clef F

3 **The staff and the keyboard** p. 29
every line and space is one white key

4 **Reading the notes** p. 32
start from a clef note, then step or skip

5 **Ledger lines** p. 36
step out from the staff; Middle C has its own

6 **Sharps, flats and naturals** p. 39
a sharp moves one key right, a flat one key left

7 **Counting intervals** p. 42
count the notes, both ends: C to G is a 5th

8 **Major, minor and perfect** p. 45
count the keys between: 6 make a perfect 5th

★ **Tips: when a note reads wrong** p. 48

PART I · PITCH · 1

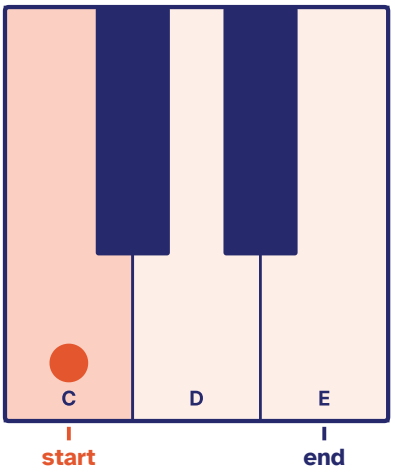
The keyboard

Left is **low**, right is **high**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**. Each group has a first white key, just to its left: **C** for the two, **F** for the three. Find the group, find its first key, then walk on.

THE SECRET

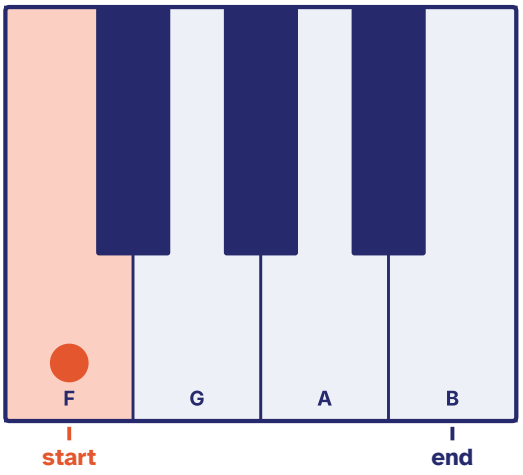
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

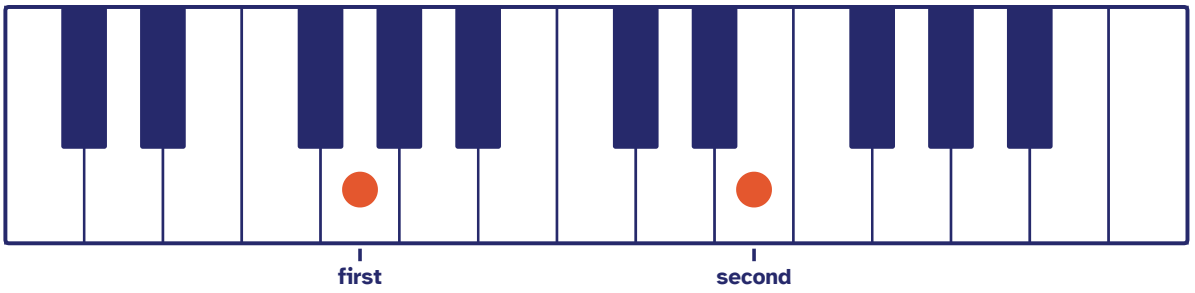
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



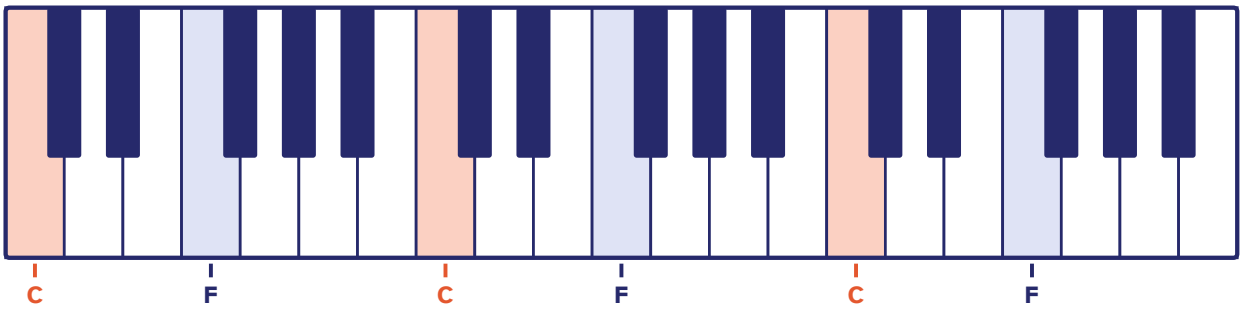
1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

THE RULE

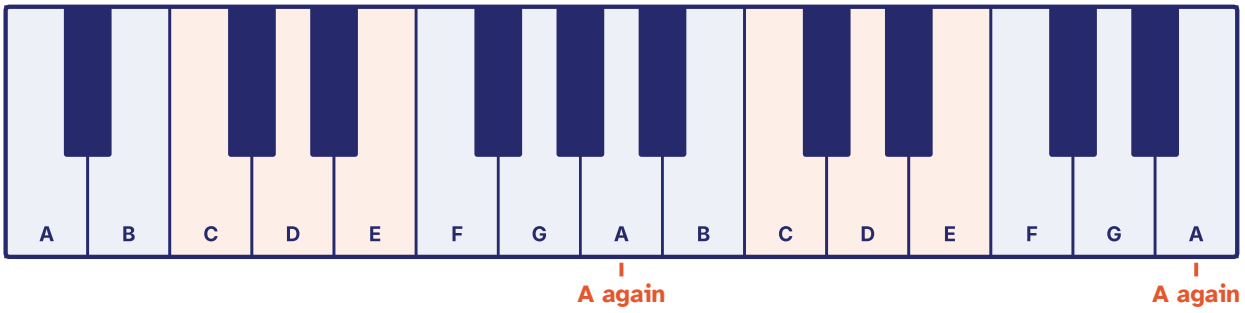
Find the group, then its first key. **Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.**



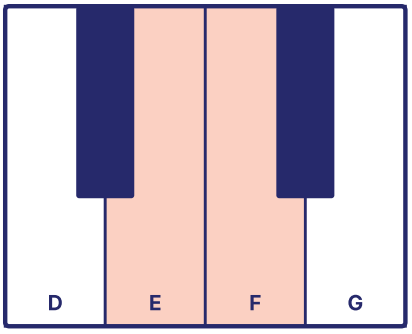
The pattern repeats all the way along: every two starts on C, every three on F

Seven letters, round and round

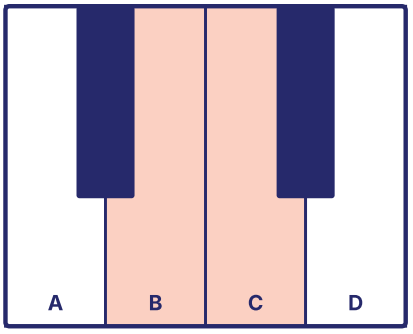
The white keys use only seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. There is no H. After G the next key is **A** again, and the seven letters go round and round, like the days of the week, all the way up the keyboard. **C D E** always sit round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three. **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between.



A B C D E F G, A B C D E F G, A …: after G, back to A



E–F: no black key between



B–C: no black key between

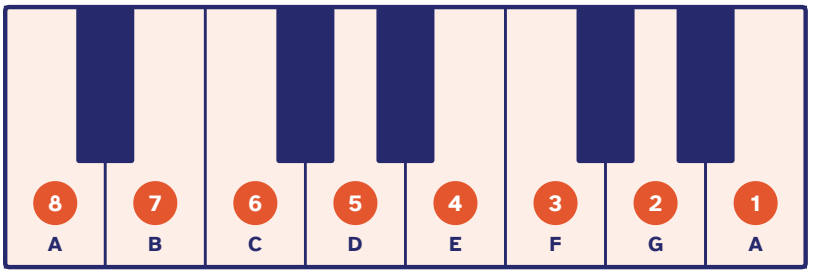
The only two pairs of white keys that touch: E–F and B–C

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

Going down: say it backwards

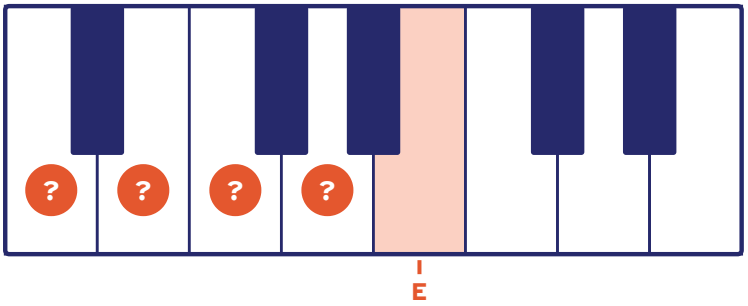
Walking **left**, down the keyboard, the letters run **backwards**: G F E D C B A, then G again. Practise saying them backwards until it is as quick as forwards: reading music that goes down depends on it.

← walk left: A G F E D C B A



EXAMPLE 2

Walk down from E

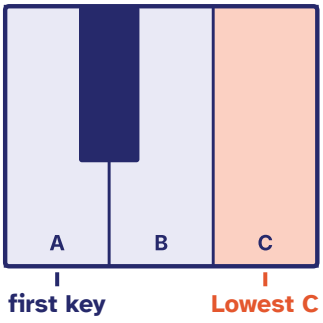


1. **Start on E**, between the two black keys.
2. **Step left** one white key at a time: name each one.
3. **Fill the gaps** out loud too: G _ E _ C.

E **D C B A**: backwards. And G **F** E **D** C.

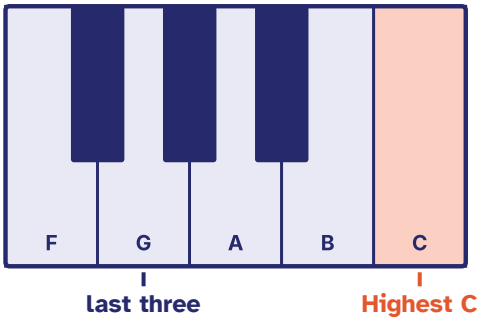
Where the keyboard starts

The very first key, bottom left, is an **A**. Look at the black keys there: only **one**, on its own. It is a group of three that has been cut off: only its end is left. The end of F G A B is **A B**, so the piano starts on A. After A and B comes the first full group of two, and its first key is **Lowest C**.



Where it ends

The very last key, top right, has **no black key** after it. Look left: the last group is **three** black keys, F G A B. After B comes C, the first key of a new group of two that was never built. So the last key is a **C**: **Highest C**.

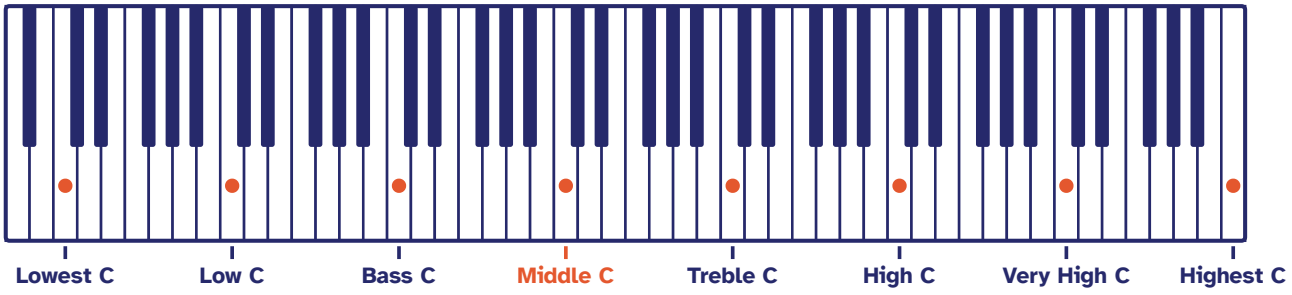


PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

The eight Cs have names

Count the Cs from the bottom and there are eight. The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. Either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. At the ends: **Lowest C** at the bottom; at the top, **Very High C**, then **Highest C**, the very last key. (No Very Low C: the piano starts on A.) From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs counted.

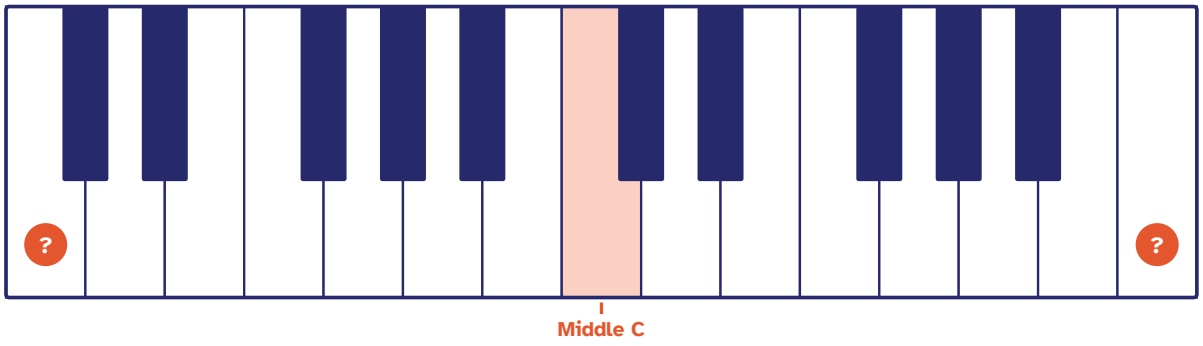
Theory books and apps number them from the bottom instead: C1 is Lowest C, C4 Middle C, C8 Highest C.



All 88 keys, eight Cs: the five in the middle, Low C to High C, are the ones you will use most

EXAMPLE 3

Find Bass C and Treble C



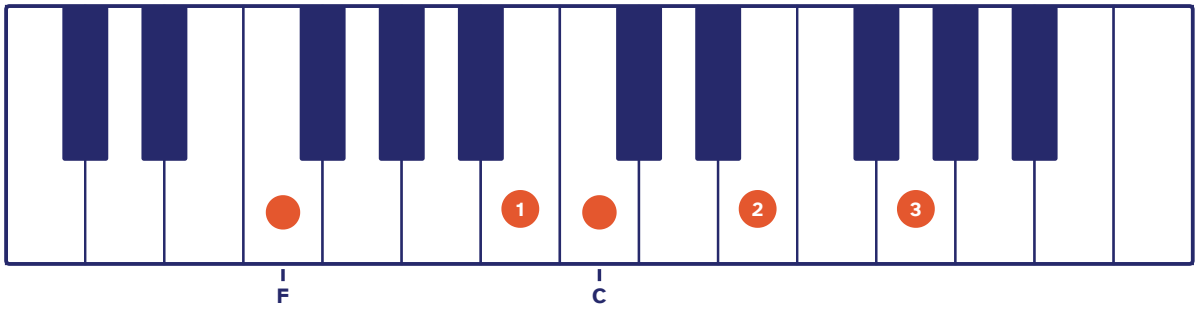
1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find three keys: B, E and G



1 **Which family?** C D E sit round the **two** black keys; F G A B round the **three**.

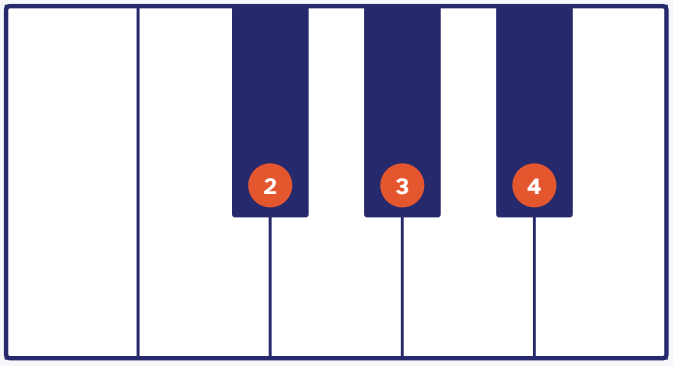
2 **Find its first key:** C or F (the red dots).

3 **Walk on** to each numbered key and name it.

1 is **B**, the last of F G A B · 2 is **E**, the last of C D E · 3 is **G**, one key after F. Find the group, find its first key, walk on: no counting from far away.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys (thumb is 1, little finger 5). Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then quickly, twice as fast, **2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3**, and 4 3 2 to finish. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

- × Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.
- × Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · The staff and the keyboard p. 29

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Keyboard Patterns · The Musical Alphabet

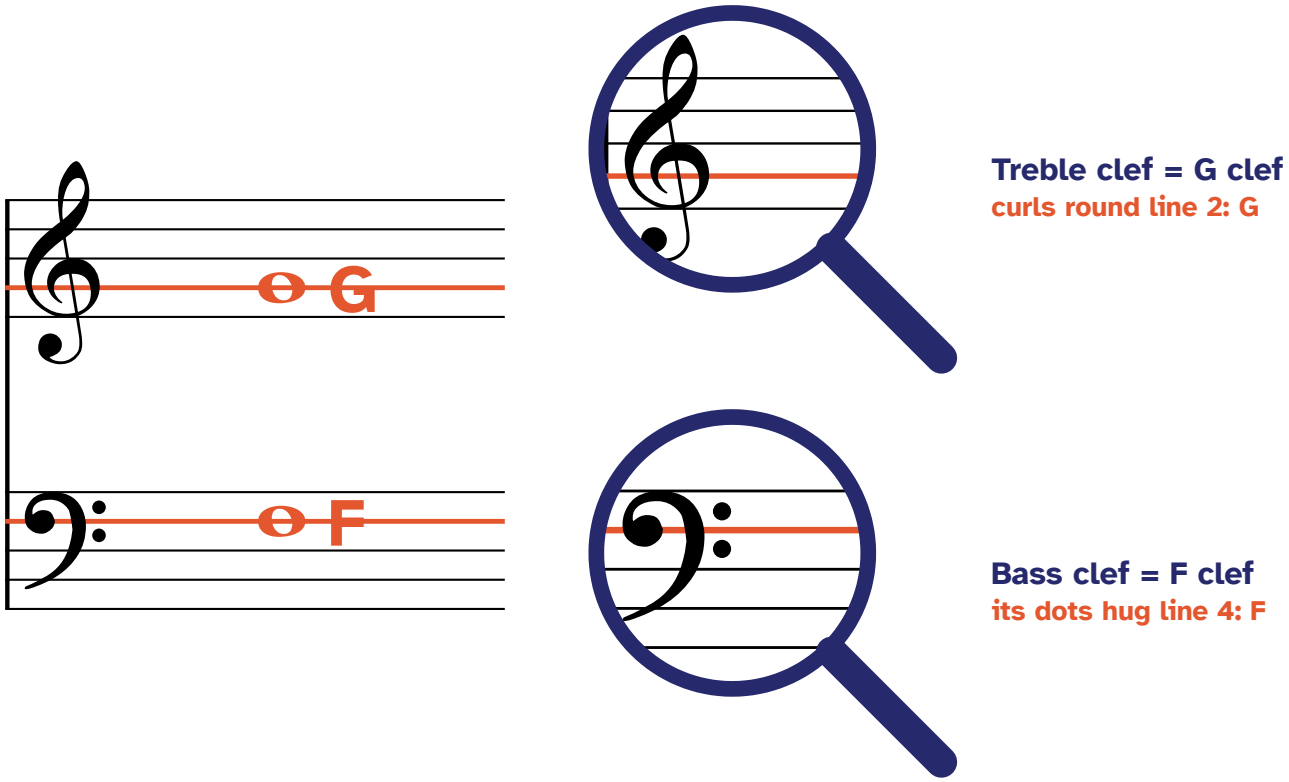
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

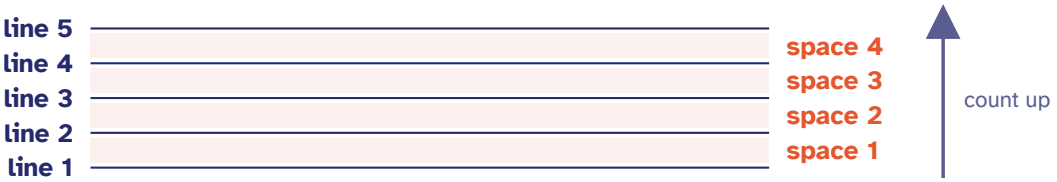
THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

Five lines, four spaces

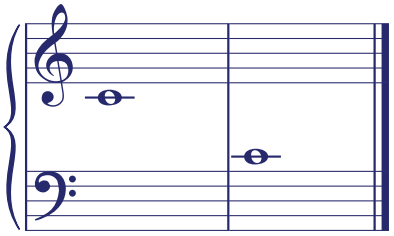


Always count from the **bottom**: line 1 is the lowest line, space 1 the lowest space.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

The grand staff

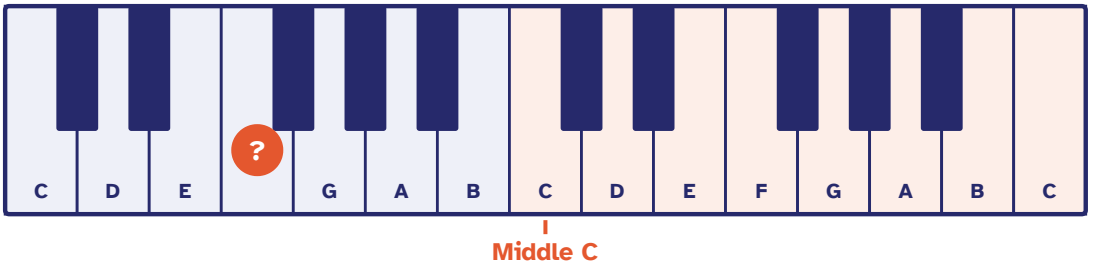
Two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on its own short line, in either staff.



Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?
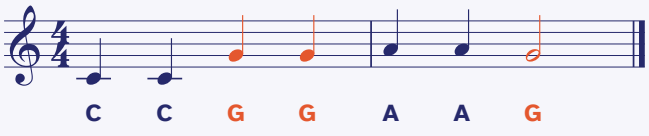


1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Read the round head, not the stem: the stem never changes the note.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same lines, read through a different pair.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO
The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs

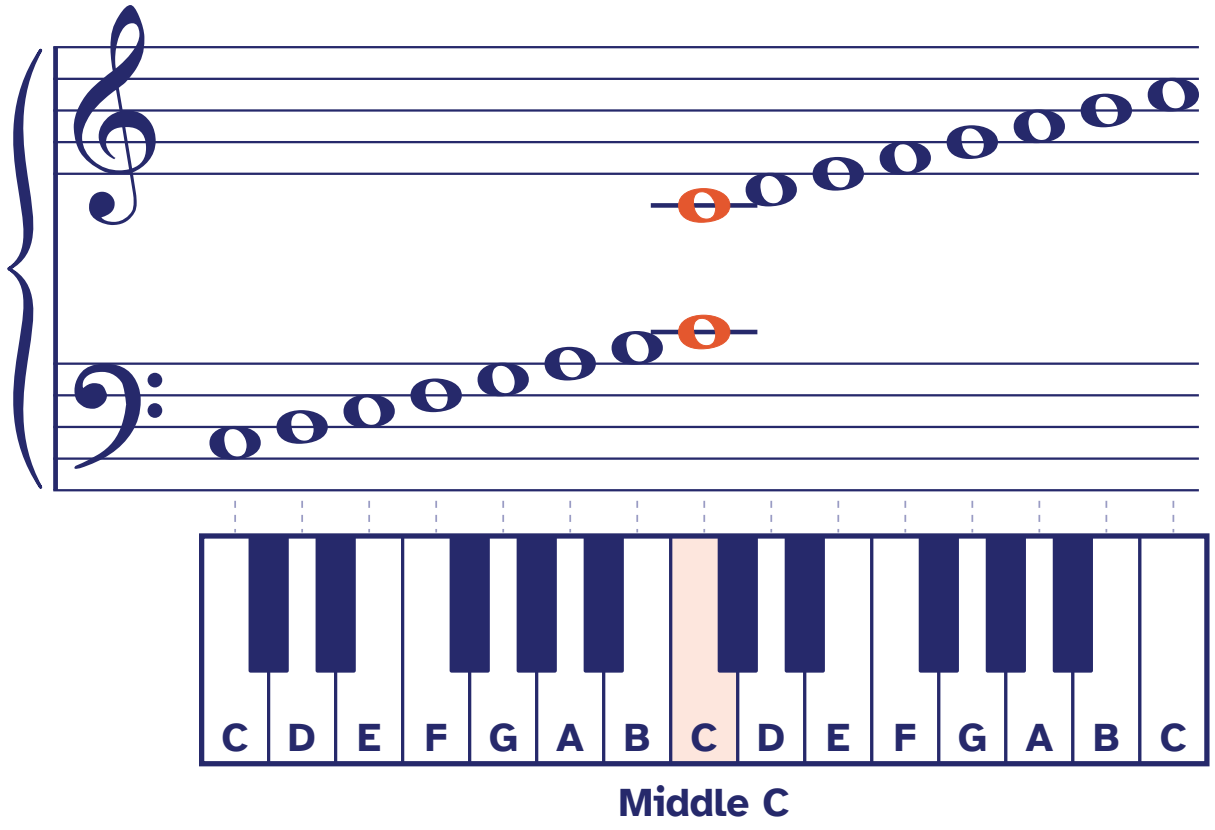
PART I · PITCH · 3

The staff and the keyboard

Each line and each space of the grand staff is one white key. Climb the staff and you climb the keyboard: here are two octaves, from Bass C to Treble C, with Middle C in red where the two staves meet.

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.



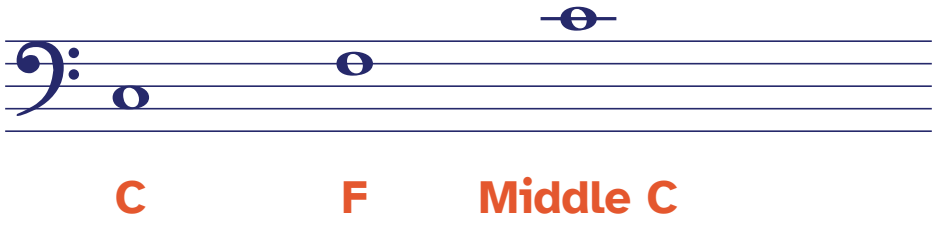
Between the two staves there is only one key: **Middle C**, written twice, below the treble staff or above the bass staff. No other key is missed out.

One step on the staff, line to space or space to line, is the very next **white** key (the black keys come in chapter 6, p. 39). Up the staff is to the **right** on the keyboard; down the staff is to the **left**. A note on a line and the note in the space just above it are next-door white keys, so no key is ever missed out.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

From the page to the key

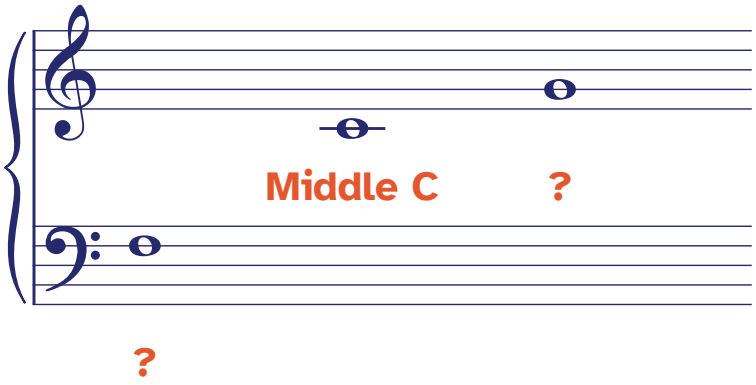


1. **Name the note:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **On the piano,** find the three black keys just below Middle C.
3. **F is the first key** of that family: play it with the left hand.

The bass-clef F is the **F just below Middle C**: left of the three black keys under it.

EXAMPLE 2

Mirror notes either side of Middle C



1. **Treble G:** the three black keys just above Middle C; G is the second key, after F.
2. **Bass F:** the three black keys just below Middle C; F is the first key.
3. **Now count each from Middle C:** C D E F G up, C B A G F down. Which number?

Both are **note 5**: mirror images. Fold the grand staff at Middle C and treble G lands exactly on bass F; the staves meet line for line.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



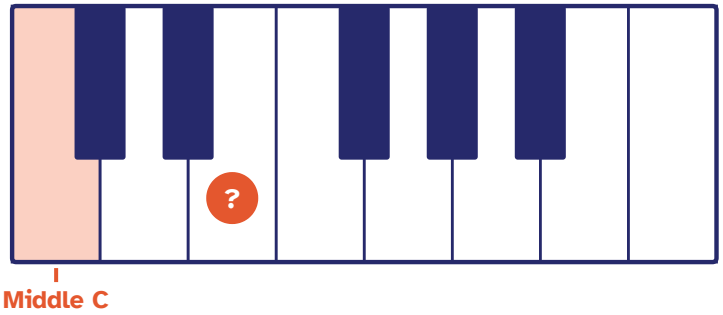
Play Middle C, then walk up.

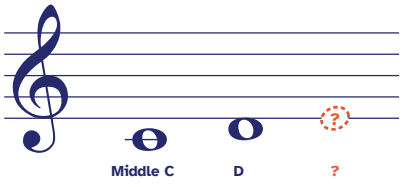
Say each white key as you play it, C D E F G A B C, and picture each one climbing the staff: line, space, line, space.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

From the key to the page



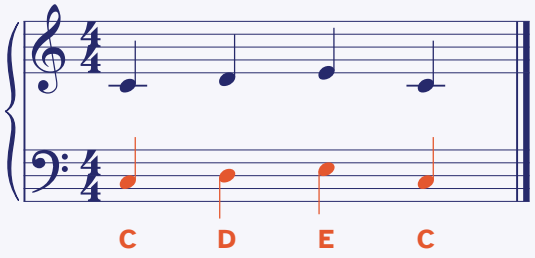


1. **Find the ? key:** count up from Middle C, C 1, D 2 …
2. **Do the same on the staff:** Middle C on its ledger line, D in the space under the staff …
3. **Where do you land?**

The **?** is **E**, note 3, and it sits on the **bottom line** of the treble staff.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques, in both hands



The left hand plays the **same letters**, C D E C, one octave lower, written in the bass clef.

Try it. Play it right hand, then left hand, then both together.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

TRAP

- × Skipping a key: every line and every space is used, one white key each.
- × Counting from 0: the note you start on is note 1.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs · Line and Space Names

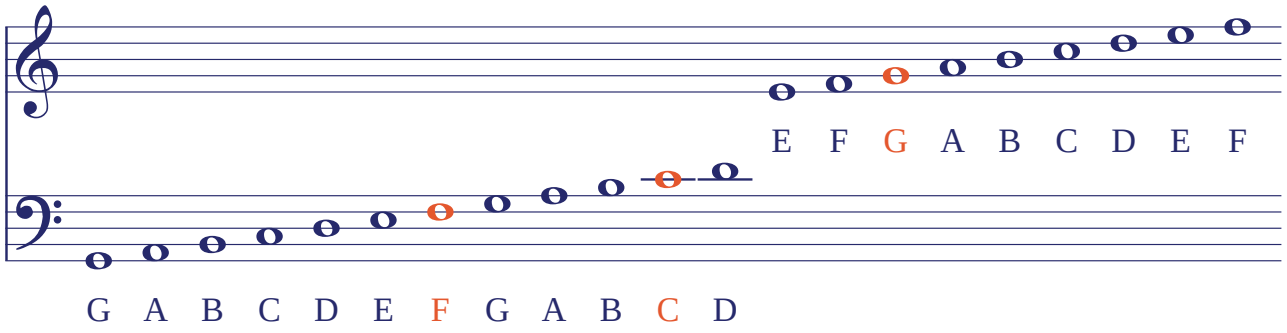
PART I · PITCH · 4

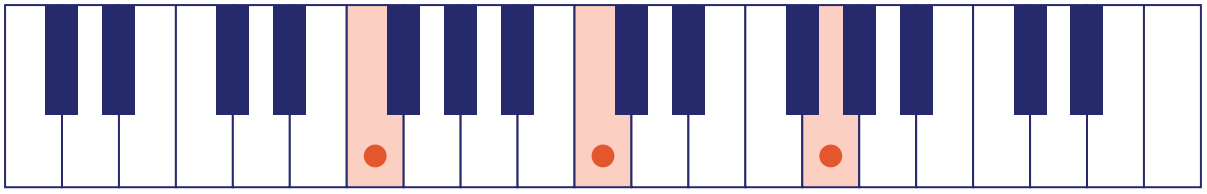
Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.

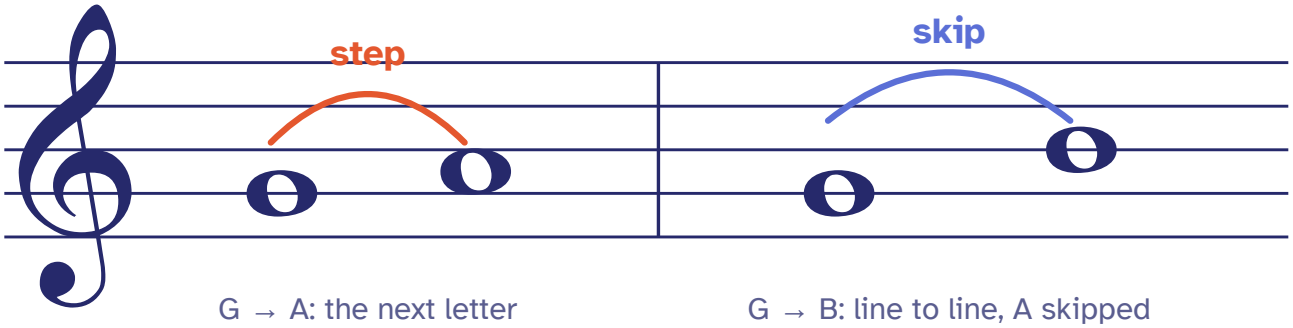




Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter, with its own key underneath (the keyboard starts on G, so its first black keys belong to a group of three).

THE RULE

Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).



G → A: the next letter

G → B: line to line, A skipped

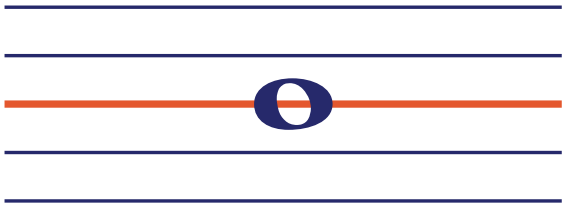
PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Read the shape, not just the notes

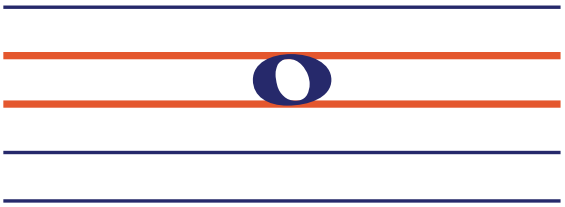
Good readers see the jumps before the letters. Notes that touch, line then space, are a **step**: the next letter. Notes with one line between them, line to line or space to space, are a **skip**: one letter missed out. Name the first note, then let the shape name the rest: up a step, up a skip, down a step.

Line note or space note?



line note

a line runs through its middle

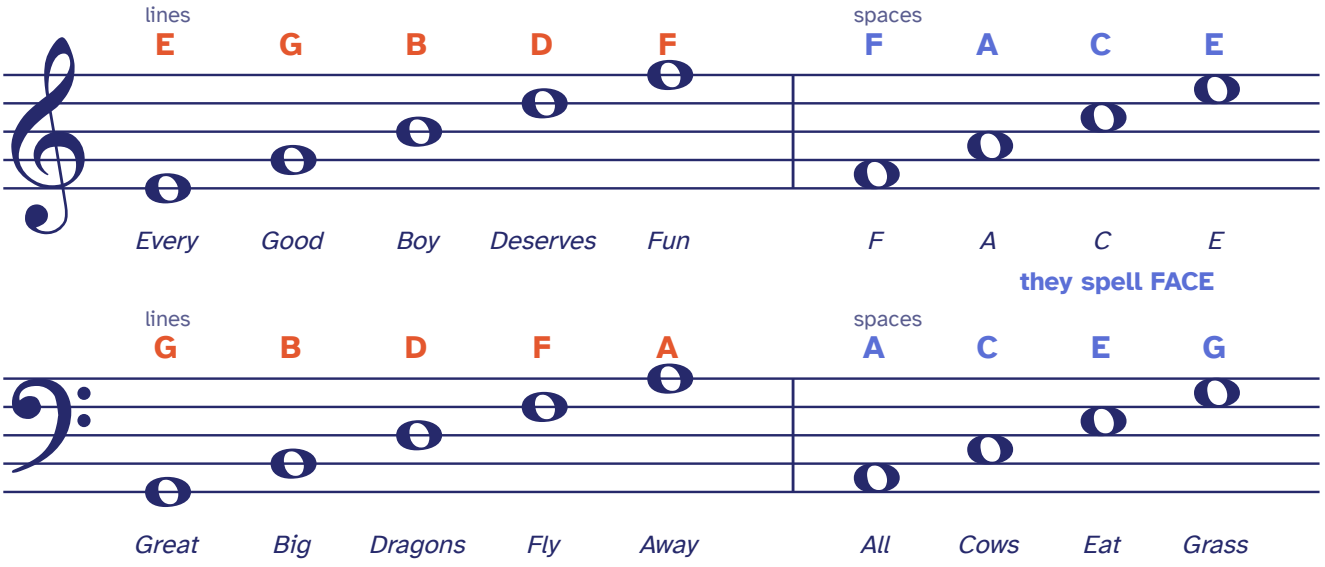


space note

sits between two lines, touching both

Count both from the bottom: line 1 is the bottom line, space 1 the bottom space.

Words to remember the lines and spaces



PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a line note with its sentence



1. **Treble lines:** *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*. The red note on line 4 is the fourth word.
2. **Bass lines:** *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*. The red note on line 3 is the third word.
3. **Check each** from its clef note: treble G, bass F.

Treble line 4: **D** (Deserves). Bass line 3: **D** (Dragons). Same letter, different keys: the clef decides.

EXAMPLE 2

One line, two notes

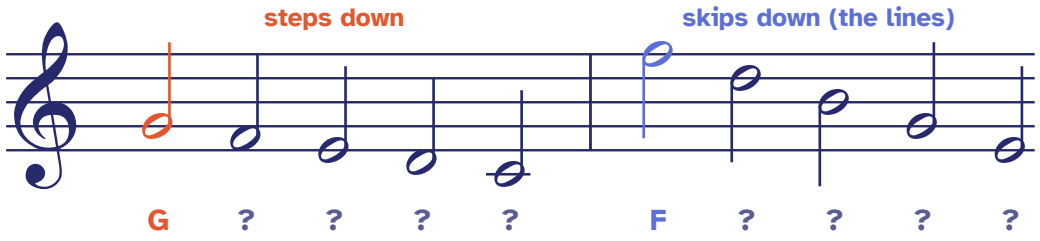


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Use each clef's sentence:** the first word of the treble lines, *Every...*; the first word of the bass lines, *Great...*.

Treble bottom line: **E** (*Every*). Bass bottom line: **G** (*Great*). Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 3

Read it downwards



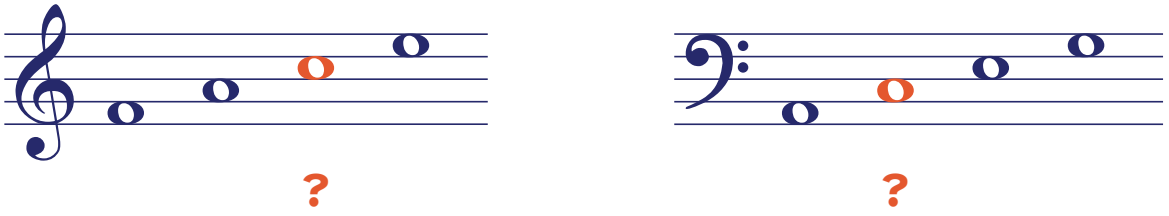
1. **Start on G**, the clef note: line 2.
2. **Each step down** is the letter before: say the alphabet backwards.
3. **Skips down** go back two letters. Start on F, the top line.

Steps: G **F E D C**, down to Middle C. Skips: F **D B G E**, the lines backwards.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find Treble C and Bass C
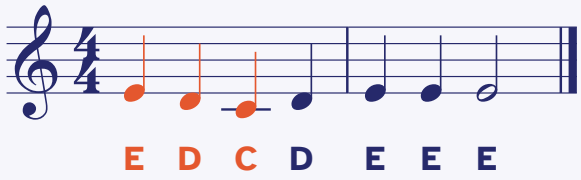


1. **Treble spaces** spell *FACE*: space 3 is the third letter.
2. **Bass spaces:** *All Cows Eat Grass*: space 2 is the second word.
3. **Play both:** one octave either side of Middle C.

Treble space 3: **C**, Treble C. Bass space 2: **C**, Bass C. Mirror images, an octave above and below Middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, Middle C's own little line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).
- × Mistaking a space note for a line note: a line runs through a line note; a space note sits between two lines.
- × Counting lines from the top: line 1 is always the bottom line.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Ledger lines p. 36

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Line and Space Names · Steps & Skips

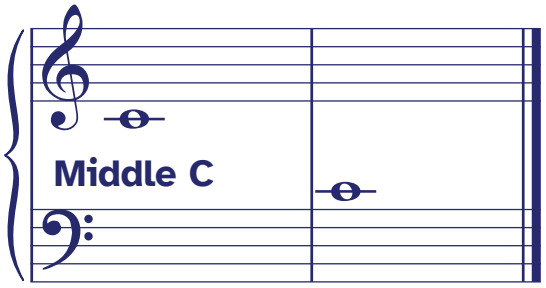
PART I · PITCH · 5

Ledger lines

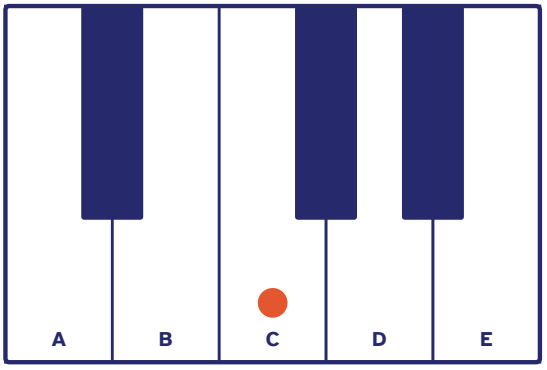
Some notes are too high or too low for the staff. They sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines. Read them the way you read the staff: step out from the nearest staff line, line, space, line.

THE SECRET

Step out from the nearest staff line: line, space, line. The first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

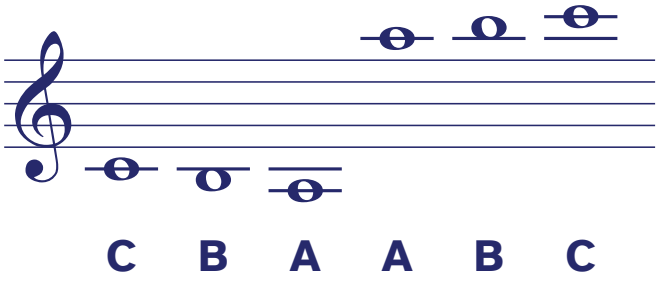


Middle C



Middle C sits on a ledger line of its own: below the treble staff, or above the bass staff. One key, two ways to write it.

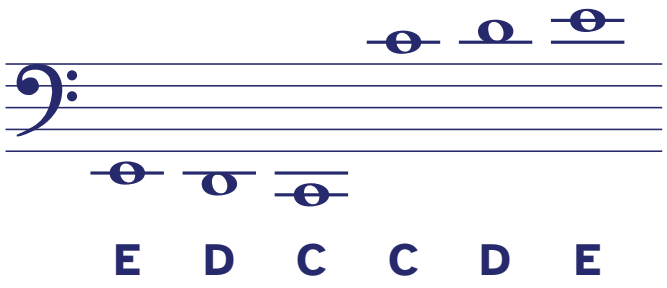
Below and above the staff



Treble: C, B, A below; A, B, C above.

Count ledger lines from the staff outwards: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff. Step out line, space, line, and never skip one.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

EXAMPLE 1

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a low note on ledger lines



1. **The bottom line** of the bass staff is G.
2. **Step down** one note at a time: F in the space below, E on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: D below it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines below the bass staff: **Low C**, two octaves below Middle C. Its mirror is High C, two ledger lines above the treble.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

The four first ledger lines



Middle C
treble, below

Middle C
bass, above

A
treble, above
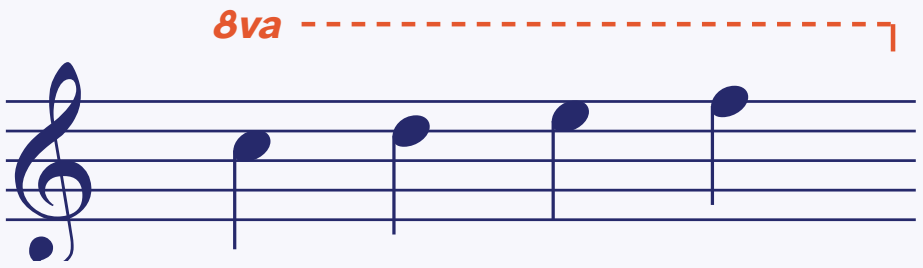
E
bass, below

Only Middle C belongs to both staves.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Too many ledger lines? 8va

Very high notes need lots of ledger lines, and lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a high passage is often written lower, with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher** (eight notes up, from a C to the next C, p. 23) until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the notes means an octave lower. (On its own, 8ve is just short for octave.)



play these
one octave higher
until the line stops

THINK OF IT Ledger lines are the staff's ladder carried on past its ends: the same rungs, just shorter. Climb them one rung at a time, from the staff outwards, and you can read any note however high or low.

TRAP

- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: step out from the staff.
- × Counting from the outside in: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 32 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Ledger Lines

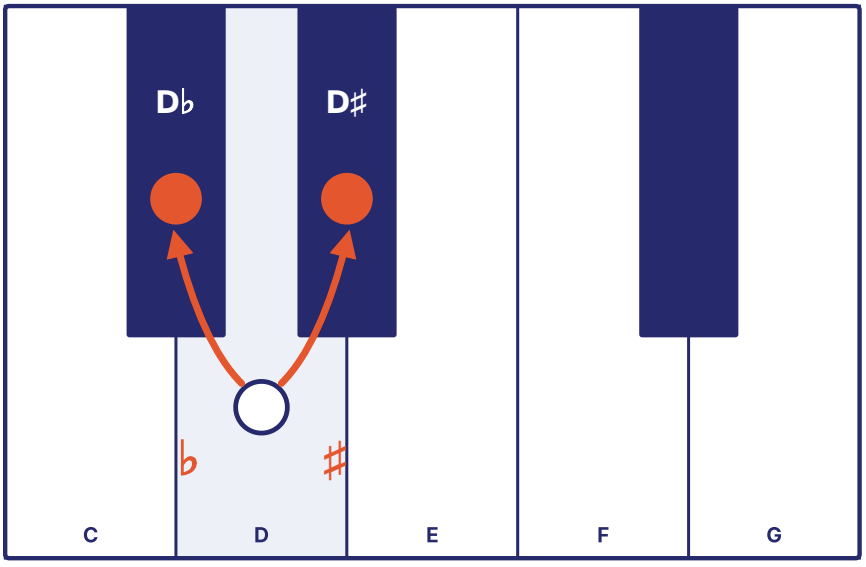
PART I · PITCH · 6

Sharps, flats and naturals

A sign in front of a note moves it to the very next key. **Sharp**: one key to the **right**, a **semitone** higher. **Flat**: one key to the **left**, a semitone lower. Usually that next key is black, which is how the black keys get their names. These signs are called **accidentals**.

THE SECRET

Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.

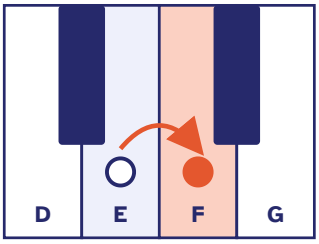


♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	one key to the right (a semitone higher)	Level 0
♭	flat	one key to the left (a semitone lower)	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat: back to the white key	Level ½

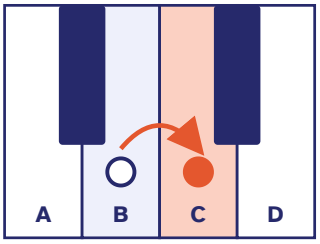
A **semitone** is the smallest step on the piano: from one key to the very next, black or white (American books call it a *half step*). More on p. 42. With no black key between (E–F, B–C), the next key is white: E♯ = F and B♯ = C; F♭ = E and C♭ = B. And every black key has two names: C♯ = D♭.

E♯ = F



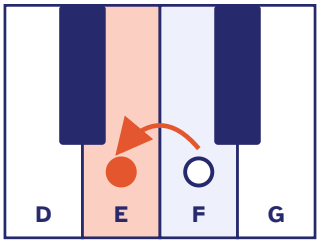
♯ right, no black key between

B♯ = C



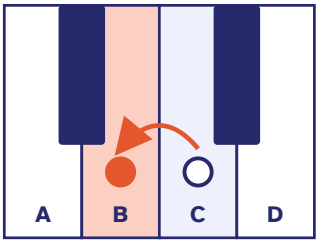
♯ right, no black key between

F♭ = E



♭ left, no black key between

C♭ = B

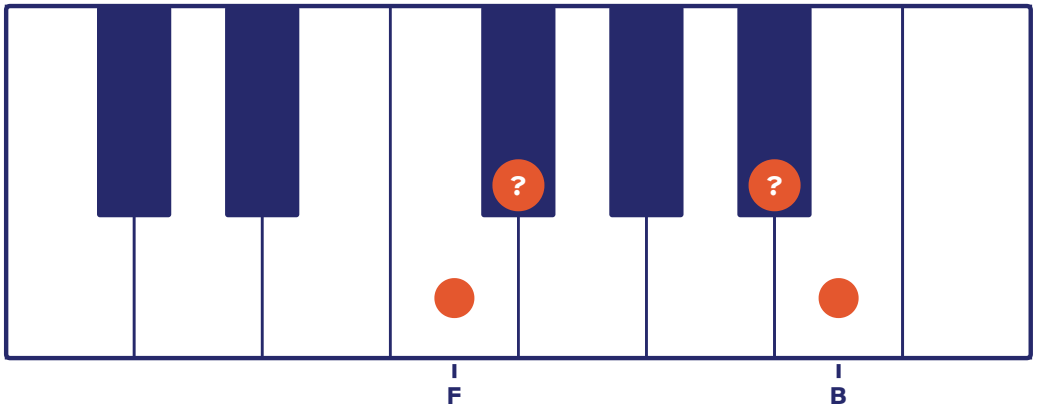


♭ left, no black key between

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find F♯ and B♭



1. **Find F and B** (the red dots): F just left of the three black keys, B just right of them.
2. **Sharp means right:** F♯ is the very next key to the right of F.
3. **Flat means left:** B♭ is the very next key to the left of B. Black or white?

The left **?** is **F♯**, the first black key of the three; the right **?** is **B♭**, the highest one, on the right.
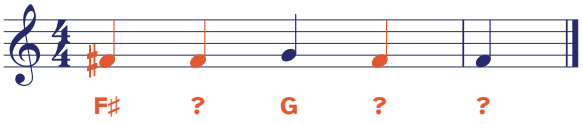
THE RULE

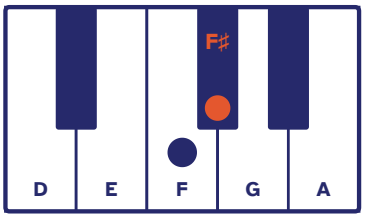
A sign belongs to one line or space. It changes only that line or space, in that octave, and only until the bar line. The same letter in another octave, and every other note, stays as it is.

A **bar** is the space between two **bar lines** (p. 50). A **key signature** at the start of every line is different: it lasts the whole piece (p. 99). And a natural cancels a sharp just as it cancels a flat.

EXAMPLE 2

How long does the sharp last?





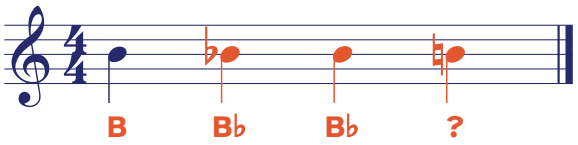
1. **The first note** has a sharp: F♯.
2. **Later in the same bar** there is no sign. Is it still sharp?
3. **After the bar line**: is it still sharp?

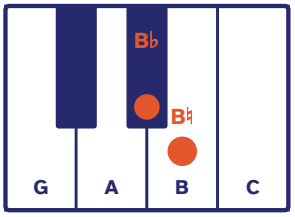
Still **F♯** until the bar line; after it, plain **F** again. A sign lasts **to the end of its bar**.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

A natural cancels the flat
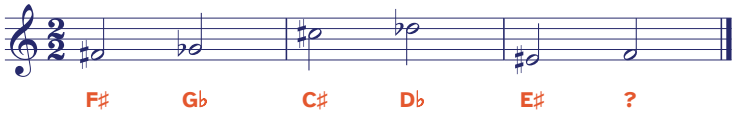




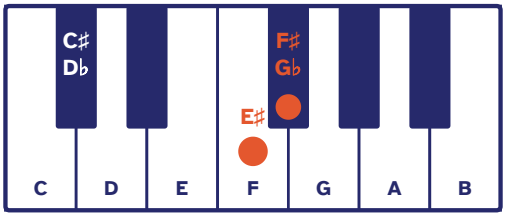
1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **The last note** has a natural sign: what does it do?

The natural **cancels** the flat: back to the white key B, until the bar line.

EXAMPLE 4

One key, two names
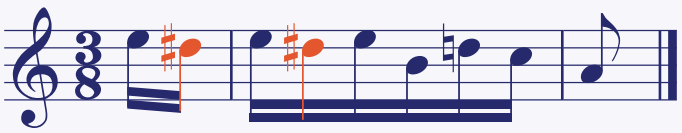




1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭. Find both on the keyboard.
2. **Are they different keys?**
3. **The last bar:** E♯. Which key is one right of E?

F♯ and G♭ are the **same black key**; E♯ is the white key **F**, so the **?** is plain F, the same key as E♯. Same sound, different names: **enharmonic**. The same trick with no black key between: **B♯** is the white key C, **F♭** is the white key E.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: the next key down and back. The bar line wipes the sharp out, so it is written again; later the D needs a **natural**, or it would still be D♯.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT The Guest: a sharp or flat is a guest in a hat. It changes only its own line or space, and leaves at the bar line. A natural: the hat comes off.

TRAP

× Carrying a sharp or flat past the bar line: after it, the note is plain again.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Accidentals · Tones & Semitones

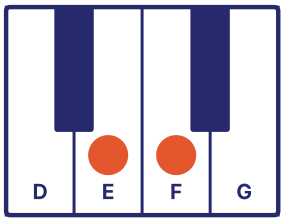
PART I · PITCH · 7

Counting intervals

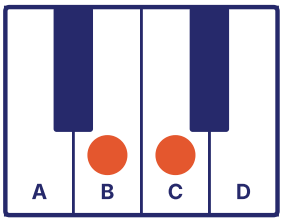
The smallest step on the piano is a **semitone**: from one key to the very next. Two semitones make a **tone**. Bigger distances are **intervals**: to give one a number, **count the notes**, both ends included.

THE SECRET

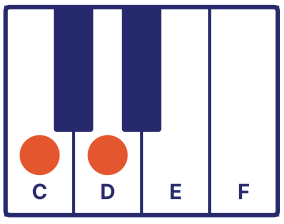
The very next key is a semitone; two make a tone. For an interval, count the notes, both ends included.



E–F
nothing between: a semitone



B–C
nothing between: a semitone



C–D
C♯ between: a tone

Best friends: nobody between

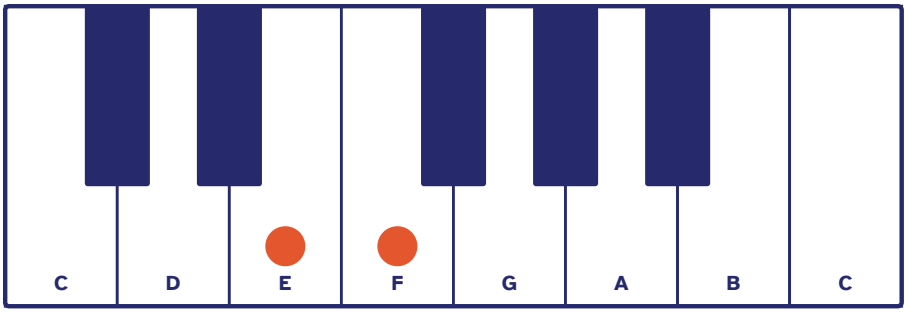
Think of your best friend sitting right next to you, with nobody in between: that is a **semitone**. On the white keys two pairs are already best friends, with **no black key between**: **E–F** and **B–C**. Everywhere else a black key sits between two white keys: one key between, a **tone**.

THE RULE

Semitone: the very next key, with nothing between: white to white (E–F, B–C), white to black, or black to white. Tone: exactly one key between.

EXAMPLE 1

Tone or semitone?

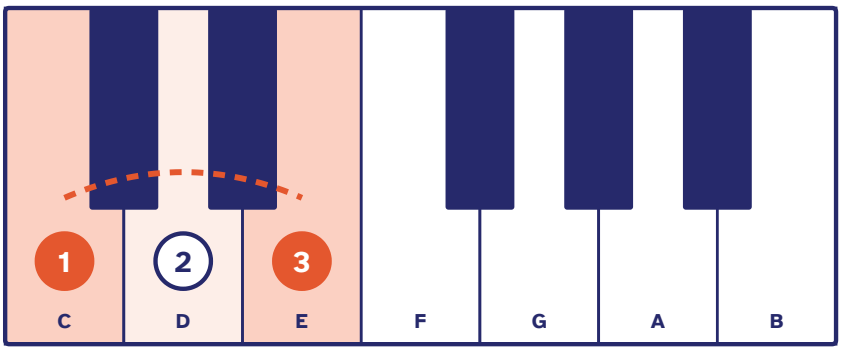


1. **Look between the red keys:** is there a black key?
2. **No black key** means they are next-door keys.
3. **Now try C and D**: is there a black key between?

E–F is a **semitone** (next door). C–D has C♯ between: a **tone**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

Intervals: count the notes

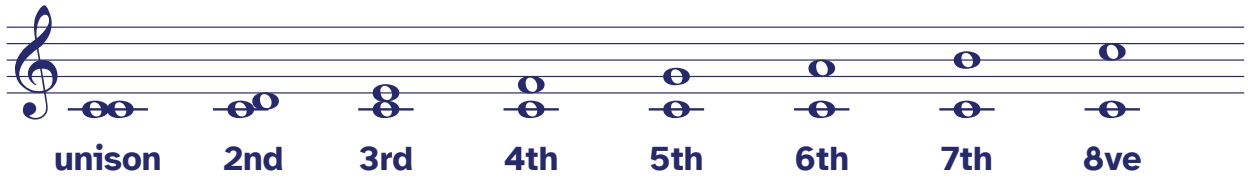


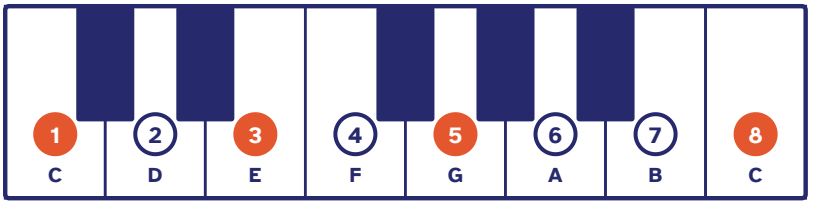
C to E: count the notes, 1 2 3: a 3rd

THE RULE

Count the letters for the number: start at 1 on the first note and count white keys, or lines and spaces, never the black keys. C to E is C D E: 3 notes, a 3rd. Sharps and flats never change the number.

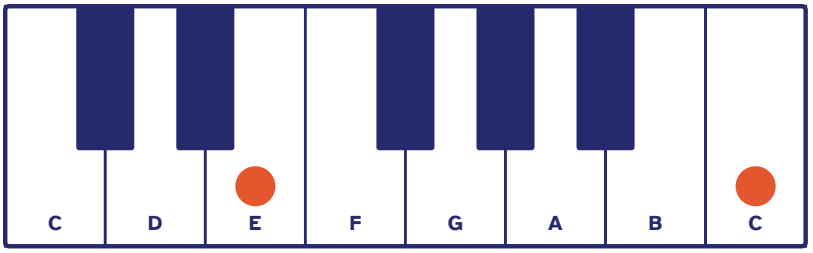
Interval numbers from C





EXAMPLE 2

Name an interval on the keyboard



1 **Find both red keys:** E, and the C above it.

2 **Count the notes** from E: E is 1 ...

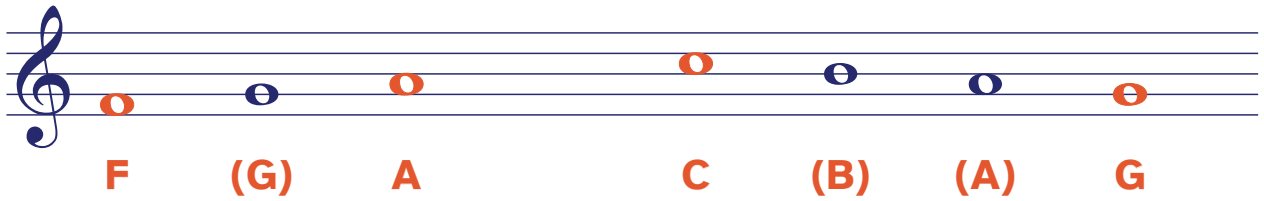
3 **Stop on the C.** What number is it?

E F G A B C is 6 notes: a **6th**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

How far apart are these notes?

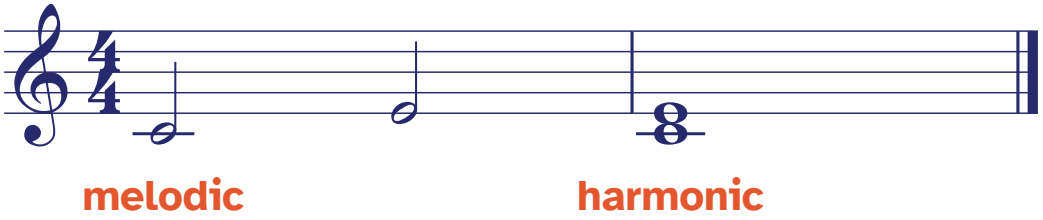


1. **Call the first note 1:** here F is 1.
2. **Count every letter** up to the second note.
3. **Going down works the same:** start at 1 on the top note and count down.

F G A is 3 notes: a **3rd**. C B A G is 4 notes: a **4th**.

EXAMPLE 4

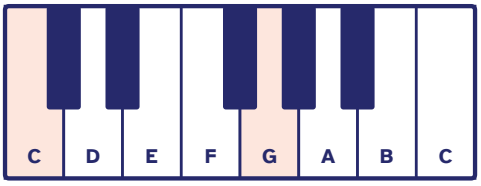
Melodic or harmonic?



1. **The first bar:** C, then E, one after the other.
2. **The second bar:** C and E at the same time.
3. **Count the notes** in each.

Both are a **3rd**: **melodic** when played one after the other, **harmonic** when played together.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C, finger 5 on G.

Your hand is a ruler: thumb to little finger on white keys is a 5th. Play it, then thumb to finger 3: a 3rd.

TRAP

× Counting only the gaps: C to E is 3 notes, not 2 gaps. And a sharp or flat never changes the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

SEE ALSO
Major, minor and perfect p. 45 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Intervals · Tones & Semitones

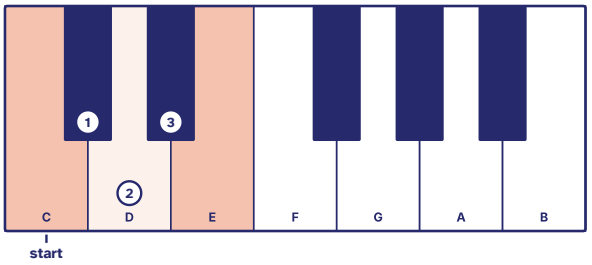
PART I · PITCH · 8

Major, minor and perfect

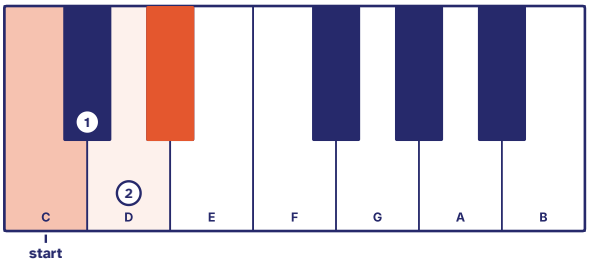
C to E and C to E♭ are both 3rds: three notes each. But they sound different, bright and dark. To tell them apart, **count the keys in between**, black and white: the keys you do not play.

THE SECRET

3 keys between: a major 3rd. 2 keys between: a minor 3rd.



C to **E**: 3 keys between. A **major** 3rd: bright.



C to **E♭**: 2 keys between, one fewer. A **minor** 3rd: dark.

One key fewer between: a major 3rd becomes minor

THE RULE

Count the notes for the number (a 3rd). Count the keys in between for the size (major or minor): black and white, not the two you play.

Why count the keys in between? Because the size is what you hear: one key more or less turns bright into dark, or makes a 5th sound hollow and strange.

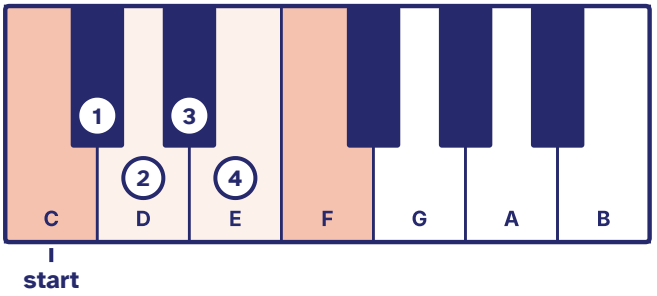
NUMBER	KEYS BETWEEN: MINOR	MAJOR OR PERFECT
3rd	2 (minor)	3 (major)
4th		4 (perfect)
5th		6 (perfect)
6th	7 (minor)	8 (major)
octave		11 (perfect)

3rds and 6ths come in two sizes: **major** and **minor**.

4ths, 5ths and octaves have one main size, called **perfect**. They are never major or minor.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

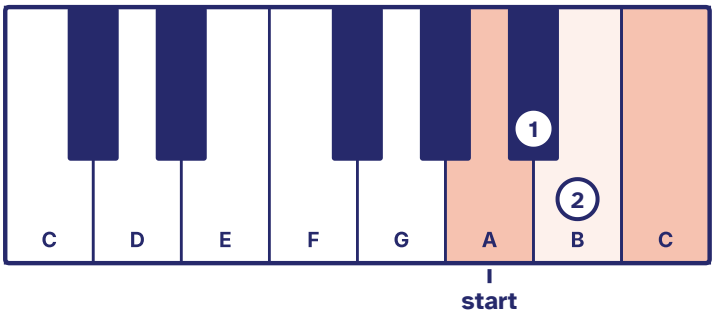
A perfect 4th



C to **F**: four notes, a 4th, with **4 keys between**: a **perfect 4th**.

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor 3rd? A up to C

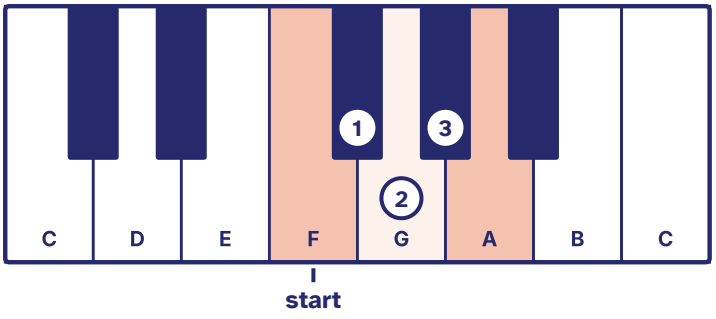


1. **Count the notes:** A B C, three letters, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **A major 3rd has 3 between.** How many here?

A to C has **2 keys between** (B♭ and B): one fewer than major, a **minor 3rd**. Dark, like C to E♭.

EXAMPLE 2

Name F up to A



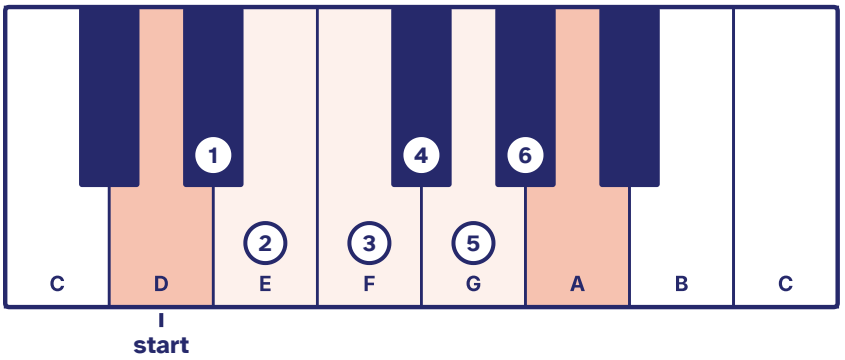
1. **Count the notes:** F G A is 3, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **3 between, or 2?**

F to A has 3 keys between: a **major 3rd**, the same size as C to E.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Name D up to A
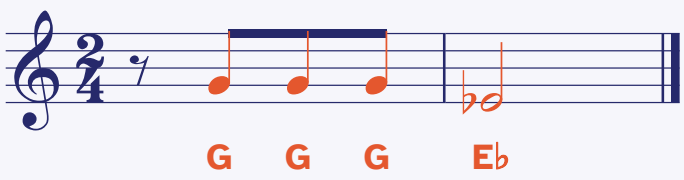


1. **The number:** D E F G A, five notes, a 5th.
2. **The size:** count the keys in between: the numbered keys.
3. **A 5th with 6 between** is its main size. What is that called?

D up to A is a **perfect 5th**: 6 keys between.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



Da-da-da-DUM: G down to E♭ is three notes, a 3rd, with 3 keys between (F♯, F, E): a **major 3rd**. Counting down works the same way.

Try it. Count the keys between G and E♭ on the keyboard.

THINK OF IT A major and a minor 3rd are a smile and a frown: the same face, one small change at the corners.

TRAP

- × Counting white keys only: count every key between, black and white.
- × Calling a 4th or 5th “major”: they are perfect.
- × C–D♯ is a 2nd, C–E♭ a 3rd: the same keys, but the letters decide the number.

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 42 · Chords and triads p. 110

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 15–16 · Online: Intervals (Major or minor 3rd)

PART I · PITCH · TIPS

When a note reads wrong

Most wrong notes come from a handful of slips. Name the slip first, then fix only that note: playing the whole line again rarely finds it.

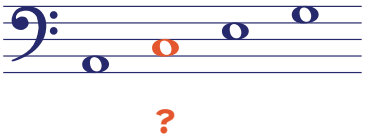
TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The left hand reads like the right	**the clef**: bass lines are G B D F A, not E G B D F	p. 32
You land an octave too high or too low	**the Cs**: find Middle C first, then walk out to Bass C or Treble C	p. 23
Notes above or below the staff slow you down	**the ledger lines**: step on from the nearest staff line	p. 36
A sharp or flat vanishes, or stays too long	**the bar line**: a sign lasts only to the end of its bar	p. 40
You play the black key on the wrong side	**the direction**: sharp goes right, flat goes left	p. 39
Two notes sound too close or too far apart	**the interval**: count the notes, then the keys between	p. 45

EXAMPLE

Spot the slip



?

Sam played A. Wrong!

1. **Check the clef first:** this is the bass clef, not the treble.
2. **Use the bass sentence:** the spaces are *All Cows Eat Grass*.
3. **The red note is in space 2:** the second word.

The note is **C** (*Cows*): Bass C. Sam read the bass staff with treble names (treble space 2 is A): the most common slip of all.

HOW TO

Three checks before you read a new line

1. **The clefs:** which staff is treble, which is bass?
2. **The clef notes:** find treble G, bass F and Middle C, and read the other notes from them.
3. **The signs:** mark each sharp, flat or natural, and see where its bar ends.

THINK OF IT Like reading a map: find the big landmarks first, then the streets around them. A note far from every clef note is the one most often misread.